BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 1

The King among the Lampstands

Revelation 1:1–20

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been allowed behind the scenes somewhere – in a theatre, a restaurant kitchen, a hospital, a stadium? How did it change the way you saw the front stage afterwards?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Revelation was written, probably around AD 95, to seven real churches in the Roman province of Asia (today's western Turkey), where honouring the emperor as lord was part of everyday life and refusing could cost Christians their work, their freedom or their lives. John writes from exile on the island of Patmos. The book's first word, apokalypsis, means unveiling: God pulls back the curtain so that his people can see who really reigns – and what it meant for those seven churches, it means for the church in every age. Tonight we read chapter 1: the greeting and a burst of praise (vv. 1–8), and John's vision of the risen Christ among the lampstands (vv. 9–20).

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:1–3

[1] The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave him to show his servants what must
soon take place. He made it known by sending it through his angel to his servant
John, [2] who testified to the word of God and to the testimony of Jesus Christ –
everything he saw. [3] Blessed is the one who reads aloud, and blessed are those who
hear the words of the prophecy and keep what is written in it, for the time is near.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:4–5

4 John, to the seven churches in the province of Asia: Grace to you and peace from
him who is and who was and who is coming, and from the seven spirits who are
before his throne, 5 and from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, the firstborn of the
dead and the ruler of the kings of the earth.

To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:6–6

6 – and he made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father –
to him be the glory and the might for ever and ever. Amen.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:7–7

7 Look, he is coming with the clouds,
and every eye will see him,
even those who pierced him,
and all the tribes of the earth will mourn over him.
Yes, amen.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:8–10

8 "I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, who is and who was and who is
coming, the Almighty.

9 I, John, your brother, who shares with you in the affliction and the kingdom and
the endurance in Jesus, was on the island called Patmos because of the word of God
and the testimony of Jesus. 10 On the Lord's day I came to be in the Spirit, and
behind me I heard a loud voice like a trumpet,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:11–13

11 saying, "Write what you see in a book and send it to the seven churches: to
Ephesus, to Smyrna, to Pergamum, to Thyatira, to Sardis, to Philadelphia and to
Laodicea." 12 And I turned to see the voice that was speaking with me. And when I
had turned, I saw seven golden lampstands, 13 and in the middle of the lampstands
one like a son of man, dressed in a robe that reached to his feet, with a golden sash
around his chest.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:14–16

14 His head and his hair were white like white wool, like snow, and his eyes were like
a flame of fire; 15 his feet were like burnished bronze, as if glowing in a furnace, and
his voice was like the sound of many waters. 16 In his right hand he had seven stars,
out of his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun
shining in its power.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:17–19

17 When I saw him, I fell at his feet as though dead. And he placed his right hand on
me and said, "Do not be afraid. I am the First and the Last, 18 and the Living One. I
was dead, and look, I am alive for ever and ever, and I have the keys of death and of
Hades. 19 So write down what you have seen, what is, and what is going to take place
after this.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 1:20–20

20 As for the mystery of the seven stars that you saw in my right hand, and the seven golden lampstands: the seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are the seven churches."

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀποκάλυψις

apokalypsis · “revelation”

Not chaos and the end of the world, but the removing of a veil – an unveiling. The book was not written to hide God's plans behind codes, but to show believers who really sits on the throne. And it is the revelation of Jesus Christ: he is both its Giver and its Content (1:1).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

συγκοινωνός

synkoinōnos · “who shares with you”

John does not stand above the churches as an exalted apostle; he is their brother, a partner who has a share together with them. And what he shares with them are three things that belong together: affliction, the kingdom and endurance (1:9).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

λυχνίαι

lychniai · "lampstands"

Not the one seven-branched lampstand of the tabernacle (Exodus 25:31–37; cf. Zechariah 4:2), but seven separate golden lampstands – the seven churches (1:20). A lampstand has no light of its own; it holds up the light. And Christ stands in the middle of them (1:13).

THE BIG IDEA

Revelation pulls back the curtain for small, pressured churches: the one who loves us and has freed us by his blood is the ruler of the kings of the earth, he walks among his churches, holds them in his right hand and says to them – and to us – "Do not be afraid."

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Verse 3 blesses “the one who reads aloud” and those who hear and keep what is written. Revelation was meant to be read aloud in church and lived, not first of all decoded. What difference does it make to come to this book as a letter to be heard and kept rather than a puzzle to be solved?

Revelation 1:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Before John writes one word about affliction, he bursts into praise: “To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood”. “Loves” is present, “has freed” is past. Why might the churches need to hear this first? And which of the two do you find harder to believe about yourself?

Revelation 1:4–6

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Verse 7 weaves together two Old Testament prophecies: Daniel 7:13 (one like a son of man coming with the clouds of heaven) and Zechariah 12:10 (they will look on the one they have pierced and mourn). Look them up. What did these promises mean in their own setting – and what does John see coming true in Jesus?

Revelation 1:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The emperor Domitian liked to be called “lord and god”. In verse 8 the churches hear: “the Lord God, who is and who was and who is coming, the Almighty”. What would that have meant in a city full of temples for the emperor? Which “little emperors” claim that place in our lives today?

Revelation 1:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

John calls himself “your brother, who shares with you in the affliction and the kingdom and the endurance in Jesus”. Why do these three belong together? What happens to our faith if we want the kingdom without the affliction and the endurance?

Revelation 1:9

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The portrait in verses 13–16 is painted with Old Testament colours (Daniel 7:9; 10:5–6). What does it mean that features of the Ancient of Days – hair white like wool – are given to one like a son of man? Which detail speaks most to you: the eyes like a flame of fire, the voice like many waters, the sword from his mouth?

Revelation 1:12–16

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Christ stands “in the middle of the lampstands”, and the hand that holds the stars rests on a trembling John: “Do not be afraid. I am the First and the Last”. Which fear in your life needs to hear today that he holds “the keys of death and of Hades”?

Revelation 1:17–20

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you look at the news or your phone, read 1:5–6 aloud and say it in your own words: he loves me – today; he has freed me – it is done.
- Like John on Patmos, praise God in the middle of something hard, not only after it is over: name one difficult situation this week and thank Christ, in so many words, that he holds the keys and walks among his people.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read verses 17–18 aloud together, slowly. Then let each person name (aloud or silently) one fear and hand it over to the one who holds the keys of death and of Hades. Close by praying the doxology of verses 5–6 together as your own praise.

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 10

Come Out of Her

Revelation 17:1 – 19:21

TO GET STARTED

Think of an advertisement, a product or a lifestyle that once really impressed you. What made it so attractive – and did it keep its promise?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the last bowl the voice from the throne cried “It is done!”, and God “remembered Babylon the Great” (16:19). Chapters 17–19 show who she is. For the seven churches she was Rome on her seven hills, rich, glamorous and violent; in the Bible's great story she is every power since Babel that seduces people with luxury and makes them forget to whom they belong. Chapter 18 is the lament over her fall and the call to God's people to come out; chapter 19 answers with heaven's Hallelujah, the wedding of the Lamb and the Rider on the white horse – Christ's return, which still lies ahead of us.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:1–3

[1] And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls came and spoke with me,
saying, "Come, I will show you the judgement of the great prostitute who sits on
many waters, [2] with whom the kings of the earth committed harlotry, and those
who live on the earth became drunk with the wine of her harlotry." [3] And he carried
me away in the Spirit into a wilderness. And I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast
that was full of names of blasphemy and had seven heads and ten horns.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:4–6

4 And the woman was dressed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and
precious stone and pearls; she had in her hand a golden cup full of abominations
and the impurities of her harlotry, 5 and on her forehead a name was written, a
mystery: "Babylon the Great, the mother of prostitutes and of the abominations of
the earth." 6 And I saw the woman drunk with the blood of the saints and with the
blood of the witnesses to Jesus. And when I saw her, I was greatly amazed.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:7–8

7 And the angel said to me, "Why are you amazed? I will tell you the mystery of the
woman and of the beast that carries her, which has the seven heads and the ten
horns. 8 The beast that you saw was, and is not, and is about to come up out of the
abyss and go to destruction. And those who live on the earth, whose name has not
been written in the book of life from the foundation of the world, will be amazed
when they see the beast, because it was and is not and will be present.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:9–11

9 Here is the understanding that has wisdom: the seven heads are seven mountains
on which the woman sits. They are also seven kings: 10 five have fallen, one is, the
other has not yet come; and when he comes, he must remain only a little while.
11 And the beast that was and is not is itself an eighth, and it belongs to the seven,
and it goes to destruction.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:12–14

12 And the ten horns that you saw are ten kings who have not yet received a
kingdom, but they receive authority as kings for one hour together with the beast.
13 These have one purpose, and they give their power and authority to the beast.
14 These will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord
of lords and King of kings, and those with him are called and chosen and faithful."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:15–17

15 And he says to me, "The waters that you saw, where the prostitute sits, are peoples
and crowds and nations and languages. 16 And the ten horns that you saw, and the
beast, these will hate the prostitute; they will make her devastated and naked, and
they will eat her flesh and burn her up with fire. 17 For God has put it into their
hearts to carry out his purpose, to carry out one purpose, and to give their kingdom
to the beast, until the words of God are fulfilled.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 17:18 – 18:2

18 And the woman that you saw is the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of
the earth."

1 After this I saw another angel coming down from heaven, who had great authority,
and the earth was lit up by his glory. 2 And he cried out with a mighty voice, saying:

Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!
She has become a dwelling place of demons,
a prison of every unclean spirit,
a prison of every unclean bird,
a prison of every unclean and hated beast.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:3–4

3 For by the wine of the fury of her harlotry
all the nations have fallen,
and the kings of the earth committed harlotry with her,
and the merchants of the earth grew rich
from the power of her luxury.
4 And I heard another voice from heaven saying:

Come out of her, my people,
so that you do not share in her sins
and do not receive any of her plagues.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:5–6

5 For her sins have piled up to heaven,
and God has remembered her crimes.
6 Repay her as she herself has repaid,
and pay her back double for her works;
in the cup in which she mixed, mix her a double portion.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:7–7

7 As much as she glorified herself and lived in luxury,
so much torment and grief give her.
For in her heart she says:
I sit as a queen;
I am no widow,
and I will never see grief.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:8–9

8 That is why her plagues will come in a single day,
pestilence and grief and famine,
and she will be burned up with fire;
for mighty is the Lord God who has judged her.
9 And the kings of the earth who committed harlotry with her and lived in luxury
will weep and mourn over her when they see the smoke of her burning.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:10–11

10 They will stand far off for fear of her torment and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
Babylon, the mighty city!
For in one hour your judgement has come.
11 And the merchants of the earth weep and grieve over her, because no one buys
their cargo any more,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:12–13

12 cargo of gold and silver and precious stone and pearls, and fine linen and purple
and silk and scarlet, and all kinds of citron wood and every article of ivory and every
article of most precious wood and bronze and iron and marble, 13 and cinnamon and
spice and incense and perfumed oil and frankincense, and wine and olive oil and
fine flour and wheat, and cattle and sheep, and horses and carriages, and bodies –
and human souls.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:14–14

14 And the fruit your soul longed for
has gone from you,
and all the luxuries and the splendour
are lost to you,
and they will never find them again.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:15–16

15 The merchants of these things, who grew rich from her, will stand far off for fear
of her torment, weeping and grieving, 16 and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet,
and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearl!

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:17–19

17 For in one hour such great wealth has been devastated.
And every ship's captain and everyone who sails anywhere, and sailors and all who
make their living from the sea, stood far off
18 and cried out when they saw the smoke of her burning, saying, "Who is like the
great city?" 19 And they threw dust on their heads and cried out, weeping and
grieving, and said:

Woe, woe, the great city,
in which all who had ships on the sea
grew rich from her costly wealth!
For in one hour she has been devastated.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:20–21

20 Rejoice over her, heaven,
and you saints and apostles and prophets,
for God has judged your case against her.
21 And a mighty angel picked up a stone like a great millstone and threw it into the sea, saying:

So with violence Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down,
and will never be found again.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:22–22

22 And the sound of lyre players and musicians,
of flute players and trumpeters,
will never be heard in you again,
and no craftsman of any craft
will ever be found in you again,
and the sound of the mill
will never be heard in you again,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:23–23

23 and the light of a lamp
will never shine in you again,
and the voice of bridegroom and bride
will never be heard in you again.
For your merchants were the nobles of the earth,
for by your sorcery all the nations were deceived,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 18:24 – 19:1

24 and in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints
and of all who have been slaughtered on the earth.
1 After this I heard something like the loud voice of a great crowd in heaven, saying:

Hallelujah!
The salvation and the glory and the power belong to our God,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:2–3

2 for true and just are his judgements;
for he has judged the great prostitute
who corrupted the earth with her harlotry,
and he has avenged the blood of his servants
from her hand.
3 And a second time they said:

Hallelujah!
Her smoke goes up for ever and ever.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:4–5

4 And the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures fell down and worshipped
God, who sits on the throne, saying:

Amen. Hallelujah!
5 And a voice came out from the throne, saying:

Praise our God, all his servants,
and you who fear him, the small and the great!

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:6–6

6 And I heard something like the voice of a great crowd, and like the sound of many waters, and like the sound of mighty thunder, saying:

Hallelujah!
For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:7–7

7 Let us rejoice and be glad,
and we will give him the glory,
for the wedding of the Lamb has come,
and his wife has made herself ready.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:8–9

8 And it was given to her to clothe herself
in fine linen, shining and clean;
for the fine linen is the righteous acts of the saints.
9 And he says to me, "Write: Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." And he says to me, "These are the true words of God."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:10–11

10 And I fell down at his feet to worship him. And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am
a fellow servant with you and with your brothers and sisters who hold to the
testimony of Jesus. Worship God! For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of
prophecy."

11 And I saw heaven opened, and there was a white horse, and its rider is called
Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:12–14

12 His eyes are a flame of fire, and on his head are many diadems, and he has a name
written that no one knows except himself. 13 And he is dressed in a robe dipped in
blood, and his name is called The Word of God. 14 And the armies that are in heaven
followed him on white horses, dressed in fine linen, white and clean.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:15–16

15 And out of his mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations,
and he will shepherd them with an iron rod; and he treads the winepress of the
wine of the fury of the wrath of God, the Almighty. 16 And on his robe and on his
thigh he has a name written: King of kings and Lord of lords.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:17–19

17 And I saw an angel standing in the sun, and he cried out with a loud voice, saying
to all the birds that fly in midheaven, "Come, gather for the great supper of God, 18 to
eat the flesh of kings and the flesh of generals and the flesh of the powerful and the
flesh of horses and their riders, and the flesh of all, free and slave, small and great."
19 And I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered to make
war on the rider of the horse and on his army.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 19:20–21

20 And the beast was captured, and with it the false prophet who had performed the
signs before it, by which he deceived those who had received the mark of the beast
and those who worshipped its image. The two of them were thrown alive into the
lake of fire that burns with sulphur. 21 And the rest were killed with the sword of the
rider of the horse, the sword that came out of his mouth, and all the birds gorged
themselves on their flesh.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

Ἐξέλθατε, ὁ λαός μου, ἐξ αὐτῆς

Exelthate, ho laos mou, ex autēs · "Come out of her, my people"

Jeremiah's call to the exiles in ancient Babylon (Jeremiah 51:6, 45). The Greek Old Testament uses the same verb for Israel's exodus from Egypt (Exodus 13:3). It is a new exodus – out of Babylon, not out of creation; the goal is the city where God dwells with people (21:1–3).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σωμάτων, καὶ ψυχὰς ἀνθρώπων

sōmatōn, kai psychas anthrōpōn · “bodies – and human souls”

The last items on Babylon's cargo list. “Bodies” was a trade word for slaves; here the Greek suddenly changes its construction, as though John interrupts the list to say what the merchants did not want to see: these are souls. The Lamb purchased people for God (5:9); Babylon buys and sells them.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πιστὸς … καὶ ἀληθινός

pistos … kai alēthinos · “Faithful and True”

Pistos is someone who keeps his word; alēthinos is the genuine thing as against the counterfeit. In a book full of counterfeits – a beast that looks as though slain (13:3), a false prophet with horns like a lamb (13:11) – the Rider is the Genuine One. It is how Jesus introduced himself to Laodicea (3:14).

THE BIG IDEA

Babylon – the seductive power of every age that rides on the beast, lives in luxury, trades in bodies and souls and is drunk with the blood of the saints – looks impressive but falls in a single hour; God calls his people to come out of her, not out of the world, and invites them to the wedding of the Lamb, whose Rider, Faithful and True, conquers by the word of his mouth.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

John hears of “the great prostitute who sits on many waters”, then sees “a woman sitting on a scarlet beast”. How does the seeing interpret the hearing? What would the churches have recognised when the angel speaks of seven mountains and of “the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of the earth”?

Revelation 17:1–18

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“And when I saw her, I was greatly amazed.” The angel asks: “Why are you amazed?” Babylon appears not as a monster but as a queen in purple with a golden cup. What impresses you so much at the moment that it begins to draw your heart away from the Lamb? Behind the glamour, what is it riding on – and who pays for it?

Revelation 17:3–7

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The Old Testament in the New: read Jeremiah 51:6–8 and Isaiah 47:7–8 aloud and compare them with 18:2–8. What does it tell us that the voice from heaven uses Jeremiah's words, “Come out of her, my people”? What kind of exodus is this – out of the world, or out of something else? What would it mean for your work and your spending?

Revelation 18:2–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

In her heart Babylon says: “I sit as a queen; I am no widow, and I will never see grief.” Laodicea said: “I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing” (3:17). Where do you hear that voice in your own heart – “if I have enough, nothing can touch me”?

Revelation 18:7

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The merchants do not weep over the city or over the slaves, but “because no one buys their cargo any more” – and the list ends with “bodies – and human souls”. What does our grief show about what our hearts are bound to? Who might be only “cargo” to us – people whose work we use without really seeing them?

Revelation 18:11–24

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Hallelujah, “for the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready.” The prostitute bought her purple and gold; the bride is given fine linen, shining and clean. Do you see the church more as a failure or as the bride of the Lamb? And do you try to earn your robe, or receive it as a gift?

Revelation 19:1–10

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The Rider is “called Faithful and True”; his robe is dipped in blood before any fight, and no battle is described – only the sword from his mouth. Which of God's promises do you find hard to believe at the moment? And when did you last fight with the beast's weapons – anger, manipulation, power – instead of the word?

Revelation 19:11–21

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one act of “coming out” this week: give away something you would like to keep, or, with one purchase, ask who the people behind it are and pray for them – not out of guilt, but as someone who already belongs to the Lamb.
- Choose one conversation in which you are tempted to win with harsh words. Pray Hebrews 4:12 beforehand, and then speak one true word in love instead of the word that wounds.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 19:6–8 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: name before God one thing that amazes you more than the Lamb; pray for people who are treated as cargo – exploited workers, trafficked people, those whose worth is measured by what they produce; and thank the Rider, Faithful and True, for one promise he has kept. Close together: "Hallelujah! For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign."

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 11

Come, Lord Jesus

Revelation 20:1 – 22:21

TO GET STARTED

What is the best homecoming you can remember – after a journey, a stay in hospital or a long time away? What made it feel like home?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 19 showed Christ's return. Chapter 20 steps back once more and shows the time we live in from another angle: the dragon bound for a thousand years while Christ reigns with his people, then the last short revolt and the great white throne. Chapters 21–22 show what remains when everything evil is gone: a new heaven and a new earth, the bride who is a city, the river and the tree of life from Eden, and the face of God. And the book ends as it began – as a letter to the seven churches, with the promise “I am coming soon” and with grace.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:1–3

[1] And I saw an angel coming down from heaven, holding in his hand the key of the abyss and a great chain. [2] And he seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years, [3] and threw him into the abyss and locked it and sealed it over him, so that he would deceive the nations no more until the thousand years were completed. After that he must be released for a short time.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:4–5

4 And I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and judgement was given to them. And I
saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus and
because of the word of God, and who had not worshipped the beast or its image and
had not received the mark on their foreheads or on their hands. And they lived and
reigned with Christ for a thousand years. 5 The rest of the dead did not live until the
thousand years were completed. This is the first resurrection.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:6–7

6 Blessed and holy is the one who has a share in the first resurrection. Over these the second death has no authority, but they will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with him for a thousand years.

7 And when the thousand years are completed, Satan will be released from his prison

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:8–9

8 and will go out to deceive the nations at the four corners of the earth, Gog and
Magog, to gather them for the war; their number is like the sand of the sea. 9 And
they went up across the breadth of the earth and surrounded the camp of the saints
and the beloved city. And fire came down from heaven and consumed them.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:10–11

10 And the devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the lake of fire and sulphur,
where the beast and the false prophet are as well, and they will be tormented day
and night for ever and ever.

11 And I saw a great white throne and the one seated on it. Earth and heaven fled
from his face, and no place was found for them.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:12–13

12 And I saw the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne, and books
were opened. And another book was opened, which is the book of life. And the dead
were judged by what was written in the books, according to their works. 13 And the
sea gave up the dead who were in it, and death and Hades gave up the dead who
were in them, and they were judged, each one according to their works.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 20:14 – 21:2

14 And death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death,
the lake of fire. 15 And if anyone was not found written in the book of life, he was
thrown into the lake of fire.

1 And I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth had
passed away, and the sea is no more. 2 And I saw the holy city, the new Jerusalem,
coming down out of heaven from God, prepared like a bride adorned for her
husband.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:3–3

3 And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying:

Look, God's tent is with people,
and he will spread his tent with them,
and they will be his peoples,
and God himself will be with them,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:4–5

4 and he will wipe away every tear from their eyes,
and death will be no more,
nor grief nor crying nor pain will be any more.
The former things have passed away.
5 And the one seated on the throne said, "Look, I am making all things new." And he says, "Write, for these words are faithful and true."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:6–7

6 And he said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and
the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life as a gift. 7 The
one who conquers will inherit these things, and I will be his God, and he will be my
son.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:8–9

8 But for the cowardly and the faithless and the abominable and murderers and the sexually immoral and sorcerers and idolaters and all liars, their share will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulphur, which is the second death."

9 And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls full of the seven last plagues came and spoke with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:10–12

10 And he carried me away in the Spirit to a great, high mountain and showed me the
holy city Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from God, 11 having the glory of
God. Its radiance was like a most precious stone, like a jasper, clear as crystal. 12 It
had a great, high wall with twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels, and names
written on them, which are the names of the twelve tribes of the people of Israel:

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:13–15

13 on the east three gates, and on the north three gates, and on the south three gates,
and on the west three gates. 14 And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and
on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.

15 And the one who spoke with me had a gold measuring reed to measure the city
and its gates and its wall.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:16–18

16 And the city lies foursquare; its length is as great as its width. And he measured
the city with the reed: twelve thousand stadia. Its length and width and height are
equal. 17 And he measured its wall: a hundred and forty-four cubits, by human
measure, which is also an angel's measure. 18 And the wall was built of jasper, and
the city was pure gold, like clear glass.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:19–20

19 The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with every kind of precious
stone: the first foundation was jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony,
the fourth emerald, 20 the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the seventh chrysolite,
the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the
twelfth amethyst.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:21–23

21 And the twelve gates were twelve pearls; each of the gates was made of a single
pearl. And the street of the city was pure gold, like transparent glass.

22 And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God, the Almighty, and the
Lamb. 23 And the city has no need of the sun or of the moon to shine on it, for the
glory of God has given it light, and its lamp is the Lamb.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 21:24–27

24 And the nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the earth bring their glory
into it. 25 And its gates will never be shut by day, for there will be no night there.
26 And they will bring the glory and the honour of the nations into it. 27 But nothing
unclean will ever enter it, nor anyone who practises abomination and lies, but only
those who are written in the book of life of the Lamb.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:1–3

[1] And he showed me a river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing out from
the throne of God and of the Lamb [2] through the middle of the city's street. And on
either side of the river was the tree of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its
fruit each month; and the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations. [3] And
there will no longer be any curse. And the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in
it, and his servants will serve him,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:4–6

4 and they will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. 5 And there will
be no more night, and they have no need of the light of a lamp or the light of the
sun, for the Lord God will shine on them, and they will reign for ever and ever.

6 And he said to me, "These words are faithful and true. And the Lord, the God of the
spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take
place.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:7–9

7 And look, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the
prophecy of this book."

8 And I, John, am the one who heard and saw these things. And when I heard and
saw them, I fell down to worship at the feet of the angel who showed them to me.
9 And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am a fellow servant with you and with your
brothers and sisters the prophets, and with those who keep the words of this book.
Worship God!"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:10–12

10 And he says to me, "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, for the
time is near. 11 Let the one who does wrong still do wrong, and the filthy still be
filthy, and the righteous still do what is right, and the holy still be holy. 12 Look, I am
coming soon, and my reward is with me, to repay each one according to what he has
done.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:13–15

13 I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning and the end.
14 Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree
of life and may go through the gates into the city. 15 Outside are the dogs and the
sorcerers and the sexually immoral and the murderers and the idolaters, and
everyone who loves and practises lies.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:16–17

16 I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify to you about these things for the churches. I
am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star."

17 And the Spirit and the bride say, "Come!" And let the one who hears say, "Come!"
And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes take the water of life as
a gift.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:18–20

18 I testify to everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: if anyone
adds to them, God will add to him the plagues that are written in this book. 19 And if
anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away
his share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are written about in this book.

20 The one who testifies to these things says, "Yes, I am coming soon." Amen. Come,
Lord Jesus!

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 22:21–21

21 The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἔδησεν

edēsen · “bound”

From deō, “bind” – the same verb Jesus uses for binding the strong man before plundering his house (Mark 3:27). The binding of Satan begins at the cross (John 12:31–32): he can still do harm, but he can no longer stop the gospel among the nations (20:3).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἼΙδοὺ καινὰ ποιῶ πάντα

Idou kaina poiō panta · "Look, I am making all things new"

One of the few places where the one seated on the throne speaks himself (cf. 1:8). He does not throw his creation away; he makes all things new. And the verb is in the present tense: whoever is in Christ is already a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἔρχου, κύριε Ἰησοῦ

erchou, kyrie Iēsou · "Come, Lord Jesus"

The early church probably prayed the same prayer in Aramaic, Marana tha – "Our Lord, come!" (1 Corinthians 16:22); according to the Didache (10:6) it belonged to the prayers at the Lord's Supper. It is the answer to his promise, "I am coming soon" (22:20).

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the curtain Christ reigns now and Satan is on a chain, so that he cannot stop the gospel; the story that began in Eden ends not with an escape from the world but with God making all things new and dwelling with his people face to face – and so the church waits, awake and faithful, praying: “Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!”

DISCUSSION · 1/7

An angel binds the dragon “so that he would deceive the nations no more” (compare Mark 3:27). If the thousand years are the time we live in now, between Christ's first and second coming, where do you see that the chain holds – that Satan cannot stop the gospel? And where does it not feel like that at all?

Revelation 20:1–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Those “beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus” lived and reigned with Christ for a thousand years. To the world they had lost; behind the curtain they reign. What would this have meant for a church that remembered Antipas (2:13)? How does it comfort you about loved ones who have died in faith?

Revelation 20:4–6

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Before the great white throne “books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the book of life.” We are judged according to our works, but the last word comes from the book of life of the Lamb (21:27; Luke 10:20). How does this hold together the seriousness of our lives and the assurance of grace?

Revelation 20:11–15

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Read Genesis 2:8–10 and 3:17–24, then Revelation 22:1–5. What was lost in Eden, and what comes back? What is greater than at the beginning – a garden that has become a city, the tree of life in the middle of its street, no more curse, and “they will see his face”? (If there is time, compare Ezekiel 47:1–12.)

Revelation 22:1–5

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Look, God's tent is with people” – tabernacle language (Exodus 25:8; John 1:14). We do not escape to a distant heaven; God comes to dwell with us, and “he will wipe away every tear from their eyes”. Which tear are you still carrying? What does it mean that he says “Look, I am making all things new” in the present tense?

Revelation 21:1–7

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The angel who showed John the prostitute (17:1) now shows him “the bride, the wife of the Lamb”: a city with no temple, because God and the Lamb are its temple. What does that mean for your Monday? And for your congregation, with all its quirks, that the bride is a people, not a collection of individuals?

Revelation 21:9–27

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Three times we hear “I am coming soon”, and between the warnings stands the invitation: “And the Spirit and the bride say, ‘Come!’” How does Jesus' “soon” shape the way we wait – not with dates, but with readiness? Whom could you invite this week to come and drink the water of life as a gift?

Revelation 22:6–21

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Every morning this week, pray the last prayer of the Bible: “Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” Add the name of one person you would like to invite to come and drink the water of life (22:17).
- Write down one tear you are still carrying and read 21:3–5 aloud beside it. Then say to God: This one too you will wipe away. And pray once this week for a people or country where the gospel is still little known.

PRAY TOGETHER

This evening closes the series. Begin with a round of thanks: each person says in one sentence what they have seen behind the curtain in Revelation that they want to keep. Then pray for the persecuted church, for one people where the gospel is still little known, and for one another. End by standing and reading 22:20–21 aloud together: “Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all.”

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 2

Four Churches, One Lord

Revelation 2:1–29

TO GET STARTED

Imagine that someone who knows you well writes you a short, honest letter: one thing they admire in you and one thing that worries them. What do you think it would say? (You do not have to share the answer.)

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The seven cities lie on a circular road, probably the route a messenger from Patmos would follow: first Ephesus, then Smyrna, Pergamum and Thyatira. Each letter follows a pattern – a title of Christ taken from chapter 1, “I know …”, praise or rebuke, a call to repent or to hold fast, a promise to the one who conquers, and the call to hear. The letters were not private mail: “what the Spirit says to the churches” was read aloud in all seven, so every church heard every letter – and so do we.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:1–3

[1] To the angel of the church in Ephesus write: The one who holds the seven stars in
his right hand, who walks among the seven golden lampstands, says this: [2] I know
your works, your toil and your endurance, and that you cannot bear evil people.
You have tested those who call themselves apostles and are not, and you have found
them to be liars. [3] You have endurance, and you have borne up for my name's sake,
and you have not grown weary.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:4–6

4 But I have this against you: you have abandoned your first love. 5 So remember
from where you have fallen, repent, and do the first works. If not, I am coming to
you, and I will move your lampstand from its place, unless you repent. 6 But you
have this: you hate the works of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:7–9

7 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one
who conquers I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.

8 And to the angel of the church in Smyrna write: The First and the Last, who was
dead and came to life, says this: 9 I know your affliction and your poverty – but you
are rich – and the slander of those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a
synagogue of Satan.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:10–12

10 Do not fear anything you are about to suffer. Look, the devil is about to throw
some of you into prison so that you may be tested, and you will have affliction for
ten days. Be faithful to the point of death, and I will give you the crown of life.
11 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. The one who
conquers will not be harmed at all by the second death.

12 And to the angel of the church in Pergamum write: The one who has the sharp
two-edged sword says this:

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:13–14

13 I know where you live: where the throne of Satan is. Yet you hold fast to my name,
and you did not deny your faith in me, even in the days of Antipas, my witness, my
faithful one, who was killed among you, where Satan lives. 14 But I have a few things
against you: you have people there who hold fast to the teaching of Balaam, who
taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the people of Israel, so that they would
eat food sacrificed to idols and commit sexual immorality.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:15–17

15 So you too have people who in the same way hold fast to the teaching of the
Nicolaitans. 16 So repent. If not, I am coming to you soon, and I will make war
against them with the sword of my mouth. 17 Whoever has an ear should hear what
the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers I will give some of the
hidden manna, and I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name is
written that no one knows except the one who receives it.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:18–20

18 And to the angel of the church in Thyatira write: The Son of God, who has eyes like
a flame of fire and whose feet are like burnished bronze, says this: 19 I know your
works: your love and faith and service and endurance, and that your last works are
more than the first. 20 But I have this against you: you tolerate the woman Jezebel,
who calls herself a prophetess and teaches and deceives my servants, so that they
commit sexual immorality and eat food sacrificed to idols.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:21–23

21 I gave her time to repent, but she does not want to repent of her sexual
immorality. 22 Look, I am throwing her onto a bed, and those who commit adultery
with her into great affliction, unless they repent of her works. 23 And I will kill her
children with pestilence. And all the churches will know that I am the one who
searches minds and hearts, and I will give to each of you according to your works.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:24–27

24 But to the rest of you in Thyatira, all who do not hold this teaching, who have not
come to know the deep things of Satan, as they call them, I say: I am not putting any
other burden on you. 25 Only hold fast to what you have until I come. 26 And the one
who conquers and keeps my works to the end, I will give him authority over the
nations,

27 and he will shepherd them with an iron rod,
as clay pots are shattered –

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 2:28–29

28 just as I too have received it from my Father. And I will give him the morning star.
29 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀφίημι

aphiēmi · "abandoned"

Ephesus had not lost its first love the way you lose your car keys; it had let go of it, left it behind (2:4). The same verb returns in Thyatira: "you tolerate" – literally, you let her go on (2:20). Ephesus let go of love; Thyatira let go of its duty to stop evil.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

πτωχεία

ptōcheia · “poverty”

Not the modest poverty of having just enough (penia), but the beggar's poverty of having nothing at all – the price Smyrna's Christians paid for refusing to honour the emperor. And then Christ's four words: “but you are rich” (2:9).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ψῆφος λευκή

psēphos leukē · “white stone”

In a law court a white pebble could mean acquittal; small stones or tablets also served as admission tickets to a banquet. To believers condemned by Rome and shut out of the guild feasts, Christ gives acquittal and a place at his own table – with a new name known only to the one who receives it (2:17).

THE BIG IDEA

The one who walks among the lampstands knows each church as it really is – Ephesus's loveless orthodoxy, Smyrna's rich poverty, Pergamum's quiet compromise and Thyatira's loving tolerance – and calls each of them, and us, to hear, repent, hold fast and conquer.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Each reporter: with which title does Christ introduce himself in your letter, and why does it fit that city? (Ephesus: the one who walks among the lampstands; Smyrna: the one who was dead and came to life; Pergamum: the sword, in the city of the governor's sword; Thyatira: the Son of God, in the city of a “son of Zeus”.)

Revelation 2:1–18

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Ephesus: “I know your works, your toil and your endurance” – and yet “you have abandoned your first love”. How can a church, or a Christian, be busy and right and still have left love behind? What were your own “first works” when grace first overwhelmed you?

Revelation 2:2–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Smyrna: “I know your affliction and your poverty – but you are rich”. The affliction is real, but it lasts “ten days” – intense, yet measured out by God. How does this change the way you look at a hard season, or at your own idea of being blessed?

Revelation 2:8–11

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Pergamum: “I know where you live: where the throne of Satan is.” Christ honours Antipas with his own title from 1:5: “my witness, my faithful one”. What does your “Pergamum” look like – the place where you feel pressure to honour another lord or to keep quiet about yours?

Revelation 2:12–13

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Two names from the Old Testament: Balaam (read Numbers 25:1–3 and 31:16) and Jezebel (1 Kings 16:31–33; 21:25). What did they do to Israel – not by open attack, but by seduction? Why might Jesus use these names for teachers inside the church, and where do we meet the same kind of reasoning today?

Revelation 2:14–20

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Ephesus could not bear evil people but had let go of love; Thyatira overflowed with love, faith, service and endurance – but “you tolerate the woman Jezebel”. Which of the two is the greater danger for you, and for our church?

Revelation 2:19–25

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Look at the promises: the tree of life (Genesis 2–3), the crown of life, the hidden manna and the white stone, authority with the Messiah (Psalm 2:8–9) and the morning star (cf. 22:16). Which promise speaks most to you, and why? What would “conquering” look like for you this week?

Revelation 2:7–28

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Read “your” church's letter once more each day this week and write down one sentence: what would the risen Christ say to me in this letter?
- Name one small compromise – one “pinch of incense” – that you have been calling “not that bad”, and take one concrete step away from it; or take up again one “first work” of simple love for Jesus.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the four churches in turn: for first love (Ephesus), for courage under pressure (Smyrna), for undivided loyalty (Pergamum), for discernment with love (Thyatira). Let each reporter pray for "their" church and then for our own church in the same matter. Close with 2:25: "Only hold fast to what you have until I come."

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 3

Wake Up, Hold Fast, Open the Door

Revelation 3:1–22

TO GET STARTED

What is the difference between a house that looks good in photos and a house that is good to live in? Have you ever been surprised by the difference?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The messenger's road ends with three more cities. Sardis was proud of its past and of a citadel it thought impregnable – yet it was taken twice because no one kept watch. Philadelphia was young and small, on a fertile plain shaken again and again by earthquakes. Laodicea was rich, with banks, a textile trade and a medical school, but its water arrived lukewarm. Three churches, three dangers – reputation, weakness, comfort – and the seven letters end with a throne (3:21).

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:1–3

[1] And to the angel of the church in Sardis write: The one who has the seven spirits of
God and the seven stars says this: I know your works: you have the name of being
alive, but you are dead. [2] Wake up, and strengthen what remains, which was about
to die, for I have not found your works complete before my God. [3] So remember how
you received and heard; keep it, and repent. If you do not wake up, I will come like a
thief, and you will not know at all at what hour I will come upon you.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:4–6

4 But you have a few names in Sardis who have not soiled their clothes, and they will
walk with me in white, because they are worthy. 5 The one who conquers will in this
way be dressed in white clothes, and I will never blot his name out of the book of
life, and I will confess his name before my Father and before his angels. 6 Whoever
has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:7–8

7 And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write: The Holy One, the True One,
who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut, and who shuts and no
one opens, says this: 8 I know your works – look, I have set before you an open door,
which no one is able to shut – that you have little power, and yet you have kept my
word and have not denied my name.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:9–10

9 Look, I will give you some from the synagogue of Satan, who say they are Jews and
are not, but are lying – look, I will make them come and bow down before your feet,
and they will know that I have loved you. 10 Because you have kept the word of my
endurance, I too will keep you from the hour of testing that is about to come on the
whole world, to test those who live on the earth.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:11–13

11 I am coming soon. Hold fast to what you have, so that no one takes your crown.
12 The one who conquers, I will make him a pillar in the temple of my God, and he
will never go out of it again. And I will write on him the name of my God and the
name of the city of my God, the new Jerusalem, which comes down out of heaven
from my God, and my new name. 13 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit
says to the churches.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:14–16

14 And to the angel of the church in Laodicea write: The Amen, the faithful and true
witness, the beginning of God's creation, says this: 15 I know your works: you are
neither cold nor hot. I wish you were cold or hot! 16 So, because you are lukewarm,
and neither hot nor cold, I am about to vomit you out of my mouth.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:17–18

17 For you say: I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing – and you do not
know that it is you who are wretched and pitiable and poor and blind and naked. 18 I
advise you to buy from me gold refined by fire, so that you may become rich, and
white clothes to put on, so that the shame of your nakedness may not be exposed,
and salve to put on your eyes, so that you may see.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:19–21

19 All those I love, I reprove and discipline. So be zealous and repent. 20 Look, I am
standing at the door and knocking. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I
will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. 21 The one who conquers, I
will give him the right to sit with me on my throne, just as I too conquered and sat
down with my Father on his throne.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 3:22–22

22 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὄνομα

onoma · "name"

Name means reputation: "you have the name of being alive, but you are dead" (3:1). Sardis was well known, active and respected – and before Christ a fine gravestone with an impressive inscription. Yet the same letter also knows "a few names" who have not soiled their clothes (3:4).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μικρὰν δύναμιν

mikran dynamin · “little power”

Not a rebuke for weak faith, but a description of a small, poor church without influence (3:8). And yet it kept Christ's word and did not deny his name – and the one who holds the key of David set an open door before it.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

χλιαρός

chliaros · "lukewarm"

The word occurs only here in the New Testament (3:16). Many interpreters hear the water of the Lycus valley behind it: hot, healing springs at Hierapolis, cold drinking water at Colossae – and lukewarm water at Laodicea that healed no one and quenched no one's thirst.

THE BIG IDEA

Christ sees past reputation, size and wealth: he wakes up a church that only looks alive, opens a door for a church with little power, and knocks at the door of a church that thinks it needs nothing – and to all three he offers a place with him on his throne.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Each reporter: what did your city pride itself on (Sardis: its unconquerable citadel; Philadelphia: its name and its new imperial names; Laodicea: its banks, its black wool and its eye-salve)? Where does Christ's letter touch exactly that point?

Revelation 3:1–18

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Sardis: “you have the name of being alive, but you are dead.” No persecution, no false teacher – can peace with the world be a sign of spiritual sleep? How wide is the gap between your “name” and your life with God when no one is watching – and what would “Wake up, and strengthen what remains” mean for you?

Revelation 3:1–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Philadelphia: Christ has “the key of David, who opens and no one will shut, and who shuts and no one opens” (Isaiah 22:20–23). What did that key mean for Eliakim, and what does it mean that Jesus holds it? Which door has been shut in your face – and which door may he have opened?

Revelation 3:7–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“You have little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name.” What does this say to small churches and to people who feel too ordinary to matter? Why would a pillar “in the temple of my God” mean so much in a city of earthquakes?

Revelation 3:8–12

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“I too will keep you from the hour of testing”. The devotional points to John 17:15: not taken out of the world, but kept from the evil one – kept through it and brought out of it. What difference does it make whether we expect God to spare us trouble or to keep us in it?

Revelation 3:10–11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Laodicea: “I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing”. Christ offers to sell what only he has (cf. Isaiah 55:1: buy without money and without price). Where has comfort or success made you feel, without noticing, that you need nothing? What would gold refined by fire, white clothes and salve for your eyes be for you?

Revelation 3:15–19

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“Look, I am standing at the door and knocking.” The Lord of the church stands outside his own church – and does not break the door down. Which room of your life is he still knocking at? And what does it mean that the one who opens is invited to sit with him on his throne?

Revelation 3:20–22

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one spiritual habit that is “about to die” in your life – prayer, Bible reading, worship, generosity – and strengthen it deliberately this week, at a fixed time each day.
- Open a door: name the area of your life where Jesus is still standing outside, tell him so in prayer, and give him the place of honour there – perhaps with one concrete change in how you spend your time or your money.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the three churches and for ourselves: for wakefulness (Sardis), for faithfulness with little power (Philadelphia), for honest dependence (Laodicea). Then keep a minute of silence with verse 20, and let each person open one door to Christ in silence. Close by thanking him that he loves those he reproves (3:19).

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 4

Who Is Worthy?

Revelation 4:1 – 5:14

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever heard someone described before you met them – and then been completely surprised when you saw them? What had you expected?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In the cities of the seven churches Rome's throne was visible everywhere: temples for the emperor, his image on coins and in the market squares; Pergamum was the place “where the throne of Satan is” (2:13). After the seven letters a door opens in heaven, and the curtain is drawn back: chapter 4 shows the throne where the Creator is worshipped, chapter 5 the sealed scroll and the Lamb who alone is worthy to open it. Everything that follows in the book – seals, trumpets, bowls – comes from this room.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:1–3

1 After this I looked, and look, a door stood open in heaven, and the first voice,
which I had heard speaking with me like a trumpet, said, "Come up here, and I will
show you what must take place after this." 2 At once I was in the Spirit. And look, a
throne stood in heaven, and on the throne someone was seated. 3 And the one seated
there looked like jasper and carnelian, and around the throne was a rainbow that
looked like an emerald.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:4–5

4 And around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the thrones sat twenty-four elders, dressed in white clothes, with golden crowns on their heads. 5 And from the throne come lightning and sounds and thunder, and seven torches of fire are burning before the throne; these are the seven spirits of God.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:6–7

6 And before the throne there was something like a sea of glass, like crystal. And in
the middle of the throne and around the throne were four living creatures, full of
eyes in front and behind. 7 The first living creature was like a lion, the second living
creature was like a young bull, the third living creature had a face like a human
being, and the fourth living creature was like a flying eagle.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:8–9

8 And the four living creatures, each of them with six wings, are full of eyes all
around and within. And day and night they never rest, saying:

Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God, the Almighty,
who was and who is and who is coming.
9 And whenever the living creatures give glory and honour and thanks to the one
seated on the throne, who lives for ever and ever,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 4:10–11

10 the twenty-four elders fall down before the one seated on the throne and worship
the one who lives for ever and ever, and they cast their crowns before the throne,
saying:

11 Worthy are you, our Lord and God,
to receive the glory and the honour and the power,
for you created all things,
and by your will they existed and were created.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 5:1–4

[1] And I saw in the right hand of the one seated on the throne a scroll written inside
and on the back, sealed with seven seals. [2] And I saw a mighty angel proclaiming
with a loud voice, "Who is worthy to open the scroll and to break its seals?" [3] And no
one in heaven or on earth or under the earth was able to open the scroll or to look
into it. [4] And I wept and wept, because no one was found worthy to open the scroll
or to look into it.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 5:5–6

5 And one of the elders says to me, "Do not weep. Look, the Lion from the tribe of
Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so that he can open the scroll and its seven
seals."

6 And I saw in the middle of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in the
middle of the elders, a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered. He had seven horns
and seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of God sent out into all the earth.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 5:7–9

7 And he came and took it out of the right hand of the one seated on the throne. 8 And
when he had taken the scroll, the four living creatures and the twenty-four elders
fell down before the Lamb, each holding a lyre and golden bowls full of incense,
which are the prayers of the saints. 9 And they sing a new song:

Worthy are you to take the scroll
and to open its seals,
for you were slaughtered,
and by your blood you purchased people for God
from every tribe and language and people and nation,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 5:10–12

10 and you made them a kingdom and priests to our God,
and they reign on the earth.
11 And I looked, and I heard the voice of many angels around the throne and the
living creatures and the elders, and their number was ten thousands of ten
thousands and thousands of thousands, 12 saying with a loud voice:

Worthy is the Lamb who was slaughtered
to receive the power and wealth and wisdom and strength
and honour and glory and praise.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 5:13–14

13 And every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the sea,
and everything in them, I heard saying:

To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb
be the praise and the honour and the glory and the might
for ever and ever.
14 And the four living creatures said, "Amen." And the elders fell down and
worshipped.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

Ἄξιος εἶ

axios ei · “worthy are you”

According to Suetonius, the emperor Domitian wished to be addressed as “our lord and god”. In the elders' song – “Worthy are you, our Lord and God” (4:11) – many hear a quiet, courageous counter-voice. In 5:9 the same words are sung to the Lamb: he receives the worship that belongs to God.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀρνίον

arnion · “Lamb”

With one exception (the beast of 13:11) John uses this word only for Christ – 29 times. Behind it stand the Passover lamb of Exodus 12 and the Servant led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isaiah 53:7). The Lamb is standing “as though slaughtered” (hōs esphagmenon): alive, but still bearing the wounds (5:6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἠγόρασας

ēgorasas · “you purchased”

A word of the market, which could also describe buying slaves (5:9). By his blood the Lamb has bought people for God from every nation and made them a kingdom and priests – what God promised Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:6).

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the visible power of Rome John is shown the throne in heaven, where the Creator is worshipped, and in the middle of the throne a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered: God rules history, and his power looks like the cross.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

After Christ knocking at a closed door in Laodicea, now “a door stood open in heaven”, and John hears “Come up here”. What would it mean for believers in cities full of emperor temples to be shown the throne first – before any seals or plagues? Does your day usually begin with the news or with the throne?

Revelation 4:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

John stands in a long line. Read Isaiah 6:1–3, Ezekiel 1:26–28 and Job 1:6–12 (or 1 Kings 22:19). What do these scenes behind the curtain have in common? What do they say about who really decides what happens on earth – and about the accuser, who can do nothing without God's permission?

Revelation 4:2–8

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The elders sing “Worthy are you, our Lord and God” – the very title Domitian claimed – and the reason is creation: “for you created all things”. In your decisions about time, money and attention, what do you actually call “worthy”?

Revelation 4:9–11

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The elders cast their crowns before the throne. What “crown” are you holding tightly – a title, an achievement, your reputation, even your own faithfulness? What freedom might there be in laying it down?

Revelation 4:10

DISCUSSION · 5/7

John weeps, because no one is found worthy to open the scroll. These are the tears of every believer who wonders whether suffering has any meaning. Which “scroll” in your life seems closed and sealed? And what does it mean that the golden bowls of incense “are the prayers of the saints”?

Revelation 5:1–8

DISCUSSION · 6/7

John hears “the Lion from the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered” – and sees “a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered”. What did people expect from the Lion? What does it mean that the seeing interprets the hearing – that God's power looks like the cross? Where do you long for a Lion rather than the Lamb?

Revelation 5:5–7

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“by your blood you purchased people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation” – and “they reign on the earth”, in the present tense. How does the Lamb's people reign: like their King, by witness and self-giving love? What would that look like in one conflict or frustration of yours this week?

Revelation 5:9–14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Each morning this week, before you unlock your phone, read 4:8–11 aloud. Then name one “throne” that frightens you at the moment and deliberately lay it before the throne on which he sits.
- Choose one place where you would love to “roar” – a conflict, an injustice, a frustration – and ask: how would the Lamb conquer here? Then take one small step of self-giving love in that direction.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with worship, not requests: read the songs of 4:8, 4:11 and 5:12 aloud together (or sing a song based on them). Then let each person name one “sealed scroll” and place it in the hands of the Lamb, trusting that our prayers are kept before the throne. Close by reading 5:13 together and answering “Amen.”

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 5

Who Can Stand?

Revelation 6:1 – 7:17

TO GET STARTED

When you hear bad news on the radio or read it on your phone, what is your first reaction – switch off, worry, look for an explanation, or pray? Why?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapters 4–5 John saw the throne in heaven and the Lamb who alone is worthy to take the scroll. Now the Lamb opens the seals one by one: four riders, the souls under the altar, and a sky rolled up like a scroll (chapter 6). For the small churches in Asia, who knew war, famine and the pressure of Rome, this was no fantasy. Before the seventh seal the story pauses (chapter 7): God seals his servants, and John sees the crowd that no one could count.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:1–3

1 And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals, and I heard one of the
four living creatures say with a voice like thunder, "Come!" 2 And I looked, and there
was a white horse, and its rider had a bow; and a crown was given to him, and he
went out conquering and to conquer.

3 And when he opened the second seal, I heard the second living creature say,
"Come!"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:4–5

4 And another horse came out, fiery red; and its rider was allowed to take peace from
the earth, so that people would slaughter one another; and a great sword was given
to him.

5 And when he opened the third seal, I heard the third living creature say, "Come!"
And I looked, and there was a black horse, and its rider had a pair of scales in his
hand.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:6–7

6 And I heard something like a voice in the middle of the four living creatures,
saying, "A quart of wheat for a denarius, and three quarts of barley for a denarius,
but do not harm the oil and the wine!"

7 And when he opened the fourth seal, I heard the voice of the fourth living creature
say, "Come!"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:8–9

8 And I looked, and there was a pale green horse, and the name of its rider was
Death, and Hades followed with him. And they were given authority over a fourth
of the earth, to kill with sword and with famine and with pestilence and by the wild
beasts of the earth.

9 And when he opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar the souls of those who had
been slaughtered because of the word of God and because of the testimony they
had.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:10–11

10 And they cried out with a loud voice, "How long, holy and true Master, will you
not judge and avenge our blood on those who live on the earth?" 11 And each of them
was given a white robe, and they were told to rest a little longer, until their fellow
servants and their brothers and sisters, who were about to be killed as they
themselves had been, were complete in number.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:12–14

12 And I saw when he opened the sixth seal: there was a great earthquake, and the
sun became black like sackcloth made of hair, and the whole moon became like
blood, 13 and the stars of the sky fell to the earth, as a fig tree drops its unripe figs
when it is shaken by a strong wind. 14 And the sky receded like a scroll being rolled
up, and every mountain and island was moved from its place.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 6:15–17

15 And the kings of the earth and the nobles and the generals and the rich and the
powerful and every slave and free person hid themselves in the caves and among
the rocks of the mountains, 16 and they say to the mountains and the rocks, "Fall on
us and hide us from the face of the one seated on the throne and from the wrath of
the Lamb, 17 for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:1–3

[1] After this I saw four angels standing at the four corners of the earth, holding back
the four winds of the earth, so that no wind would blow on the earth or on the sea
or on any tree. [2] And I saw another angel coming up from the rising of the sun, with
the seal of the living God. And he cried out with a loud voice to the four angels who
had been allowed to harm the earth and the sea, [3] saying, "Do not harm the earth or
the sea or the trees until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:4–7

4 And I heard the number of those who were sealed: a hundred and forty-four
thousand, sealed from every tribe of the people of Israel: 5 from the tribe of Judah
twelve thousand sealed, from the tribe of Reuben twelve thousand, from the tribe
of Gad twelve thousand, 6 from the tribe of Asher twelve thousand, from the tribe of
Naphtali twelve thousand, from the tribe of Manasseh twelve thousand, 7 from the
tribe of Simeon twelve thousand, from the tribe of Levi twelve thousand, from the
tribe of Issachar twelve thousand,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:8–10

8 from the tribe of Zebulun twelve thousand, from the tribe of Joseph twelve
thousand, from the tribe of Benjamin twelve thousand sealed.

9 After this I looked, and look, a great crowd that no one could count, from every
nation and all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and
before the Lamb, dressed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands. 10 And
they cry out with a loud voice:

To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:11–12

11 And all the angels stood around the throne and around the elders and the four
living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne and worshipped God,
12 saying:

Amen! The praise and the glory and the wisdom
and the thanksgiving and the honour and the power and the strength
be to our God for ever and ever. Amen.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:13–14

13 And one of the elders spoke up and said to me, "These who are dressed in white
robes – who are they, and where have they come from?" 14 And I said to him, "My
lord, you know." And he said to me: These are the ones who are coming out of the
great affliction; they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of
the Lamb.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:15–16

15 That is why they are before the throne of God
and serve him day and night in his temple,
and the one seated on the throne will spread his tent over them.
16 They will hunger no more and thirst no more,
and the sun will not strike them, nor any scorching heat,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 7:17–17

17 for the Lamb in the middle of the throne will shepherd them
and lead them to springs of the water of life,
and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἐδόθη

edothē · “was given”

The crown, the sword and the authority are given to the riders (6:2, 4, 8). The passive points to God as the one who permits – and limits: the oil and the wine are spared, Death is given a fourth of the earth, not the whole. As in Job 1–2, the destroyer can go only as far as God allows.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σταθῆναι / ἑστῶτες

stathēnai / hestōtes · "stand / standing"

Chapter 6 ends with the question of Nahum 1:6: "who can stand?" (6:17). Chapter 7 answers it: a crowd "standing before the throne and before the Lamb" (7:9) – not in their own strength, but because the Lamb himself stood first, "as though slaughtered" (5:6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σφραγῖδα

sphragida · "seal"

A seal was the mark of ownership and authenticity – a signet ring in the wax of a letter, a stamp on a cargo. What is sealed belongs to someone and is guarded by him. God's servants are sealed on their foreheads before the storm comes (7:3).

THE BIG IDEA

The Lamb who was slaughtered holds the seals: war, hunger and death ride out only when he opens them and only as far as God allows – and to the great question "who can stand?" the answer is a countless crowd from every nation, sealed by God and washed in the blood of the Lamb.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Each rider comes out only when the Lamb opens a seal, and each time something is given: “a crown was given to him”, “a great sword was given to him”. Which of the riders – war, economic pressure, illness, death – frightens you most at the moment? What changes when you remember who opens the seals?

Revelation 6:1–8

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Compare verse 8 with Zechariah 1:8–11 and Ezekiel 14:21. Jesus said that wars and famines would mark the whole time until his return, but that this is not yet the end (Mark 13:7–8). So how should we read the seals – as a timetable, or as a picture of the world between Christ's first and second coming?

Revelation 6:8

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The souls under the altar cry out: “How long, holy and true Master, will you not judge and avenge our blood on those who live on the earth?” God does not rebuke them but tells them “to rest a little longer”. What does this say about honest prayer? What have you long been crying “How long?” about?

Revelation 6:9–11

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Kings, generals and the rich hide in the caves – but also “every slave and free person”. They hide “from the wrath of the Lamb”. How can the wrath of the one who was slaughtered for the world be both the most serious and the most hopeful word in the chapter? On whom or what are you relying to stand on that day?

Revelation 6:15–17

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Before the storm God's servants are sealed on their foreheads (compare Exodus 12:13; Ezekiel 9:4–6). In Asia the emperor cult and the trade guilds asked every day whom the believers belonged to – what comfort lay in this seal? Which labels that others stick on you do you believe more than the seal of the living God?

Revelation 7:1–3

DISCUSSION · 6/7

John hears a number – a hundred and forty-four thousand from the tribes of Israel – and then sees “a great crowd that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages”. How does this fulfil God's promise to Abraham (Genesis 15:5; 12:3)? How big is the church in your imagination?

Revelation 7:4–10

DISCUSSION · 7/7

“They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.” The crowd sings not about its endurance but “To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!” Where are you still trying to keep your robes clean yourself? Which promise of verses 15–17 do you need most this week?

Revelation 7:13–17

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- When you read or hear the news this week, choose one place of war or hunger and pray for it – and say it aloud: the Lamb holds the seals in his hand.
- Each morning when you see your face in the mirror, tell yourself: I am sealed, and I belong to the Lamb. Pray once this week for believers in a country and a language that are not your own.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with the song of the crowd, read aloud together: “To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!” (7:10). Then let each person name, in a sentence, one “How long?” before God – for themselves or for suffering believers elsewhere. Close by thanking God that “God will wipe away every tear from their eyes”.

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 6

Heaven Is Listening

Revelation 8:1 – 9:21

TO GET STARTED

Where do you find real silence in your week – and do you enjoy it, or does it make you uneasy?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Heaven has been full of songs: angels, elders, living creatures and a countless crowd. Now the Lamb opens the seventh seal – and there is silence. An angel offers incense with the prayers of all the saints, throws fire from the altar on the earth, and seven trumpets sound (chapters 8–9). The images come from the exodus: hail, blood, darkness and locusts, as in Egypt. For the small churches in Asia, under the power of Rome, this said: God still acts against every empire that behaves like Egypt.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:1–3

1 And when he opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about half an
hour. 2 And I saw the seven angels who stand before God, and seven trumpets were
given to them.

3 And another angel came and stood at the altar, holding a golden censer. And much
incense was given to him, so that he would put it with the prayers of all the saints on
the golden altar before the throne.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:4–6

4 And the smoke of the incense went up with the prayers of the saints from the hand
of the angel before God. 5 And the angel took the censer and filled it with the fire of
the altar and threw it on the earth; and there were thunder and sounds and
lightning and an earthquake.

6 And the seven angels who had the seven trumpets made themselves ready to blow
the trumpet.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:7–8

7 And the first blew the trumpet; and there came hail and fire, mixed with blood,
and it was thrown on the earth. And a third of the earth was burnt up, and a third of
the trees were burnt up, and all the green grass was burnt up.

8 And the second angel blew the trumpet; and something like a great mountain
burning with fire was thrown into the sea. And a third of the sea became blood,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:9–11

9 and a third of the creatures in the sea that had life died, and a third of the ships were destroyed.

10 And the third angel blew the trumpet; and a great star fell from heaven, burning like a torch, and it fell on a third of the rivers and on the springs of water. 11 And the name of the star is called Wormwood. And a third of the waters became wormwood, and many people died from the waters, because they had been made bitter.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 8:12–13

12 And the fourth angel blew the trumpet; and a third of the sun was struck, and a
third of the moon and a third of the stars, so that a third of them was darkened, and
for a third of the day there was no light, and likewise for the night.

13 And I looked, and I heard an eagle flying in midheaven, saying with a loud voice,
"Woe, woe, woe to those who live on the earth, because of the remaining blasts of
the trumpet of the three angels who are about to blow!"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:1–3

1 And the fifth angel blew the trumpet; and I saw a star that had fallen from heaven
to the earth, and the key to the shaft of the abyss was given to him. 2 And he opened
the shaft of the abyss, and smoke went up from the shaft like the smoke of a great
furnace, and the sun and the air were darkened by the smoke of the shaft. 3 And out
of the smoke came locusts onto the earth, and they were given authority like the
authority that the scorpions of the earth have.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:4–6

4 And they were told not to harm the grass of the earth or any green thing or any
tree, but only the people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads. 5 And
they were allowed not to kill them, but to torment them for five months; and their
torment was like the torment of a scorpion when it stings a person. 6 And in those
days people will seek death and will not find it; they will long to die, and death flees
from them.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:7–9

7 And the shapes of the locusts were like horses prepared for war; and on their heads
was something like crowns, like gold, and their faces were like human faces. 8 And
they had hair like women's hair, and their teeth were like lions' teeth. 9 And they
had breastplates like breastplates of iron, and the rumble of their wings was like the
rumble of chariots with many horses rushing into war.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:10–13

10 And they have tails like scorpions, and stings, and in their tails is their authority
to harm people for five months. 11 They have as king over them the angel of the
abyss; his name in Hebrew is Abaddon, and in Greek he has the name Apollyon.

12 The first woe has passed; look, two woes are still coming after this.

13 And the sixth angel blew the trumpet; and I heard a voice from the horns of the
golden altar that is before God,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:14–16

14 saying to the sixth angel, who had the trumpet, "Release the four angels who are
bound at the great river, the Euphrates!" 15 And the four angels were released, who
had been made ready for the hour and day and month and year, to kill a third of
humankind. 16 And the number of the mounted troops was twice ten thousands of
ten thousands; I heard their number.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:17–18

17 And this is how I saw the horses in the vision and those who sat on them: they had
breastplates fiery red and hyacinth blue and sulphur yellow; and the heads of the
horses were like lions' heads, and out of their mouths come fire and smoke and
sulphur. 18 By these three plagues a third of humankind was killed, by the fire and
the smoke and the sulphur that come out of their mouths.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:19–20

19 For the authority of the horses is in their mouths and in their tails; for their tails
are like serpents, with heads, and with them they do harm.

20 And the rest of humankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not even
repent of the works of their hands, so as to stop worshipping the demons and the
idols of gold and silver and bronze and stone and wood, which can neither see nor
hear nor walk.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 9:21–21

21 And they did not repent of their murders or of their sorceries or of their sexual immorality or of their thefts.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σιγὴ

sigē · “silence”

An ordinary word for silence (8:1). It is not an empty silence, but the silence of a courtroom before the judge speaks – and of a Father who is listening. The prophets knew it as the silence before God acts (Habakkuk 2:20; Zephaniah 1:7).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τὸ τρίτον

to triton · “a third”

Twelve times in six verses (8:7–12). The seals struck a fourth (6:8), the trumpets a third, the bowls later everything. The judgements are limited. They are warnings, not yet the end.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

οὐ μετενόησαν

ou metenoēsan · "they did not repent"

Metanoeō is a turning round of mind and life (9:20–21). It is the same verb Jesus used five times for the churches (2:5, 16, 21; 3:3, 19): the call to repent is addressed first to the church, then to the world.

THE BIG IDEA

Heaven falls silent to hear the prayers of the saints, and those prayers come back to earth as God's action; the trumpets, like the plagues of Egypt, are limited warnings that call the world to repent – but judgement alone does not change the heart, and what the plagues cannot do, the Lamb does through his witnesses.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

“There was silence in heaven for about half an hour.” Read Habakkuk 2:20 and Zephaniah 1:7. What kind of silence is this? When did you last become truly still before God, without speaking?

Revelation 8:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

The angel stands at the golden altar of incense, right in front of the curtain (Exodus 30:1–8; Luke 1:9–10), and the incense rises “with the prayers of the saints” before God. What does this picture say to small churches whose prayers no one in Rome heard – and to you, if you have given up on a prayer?

Revelation 8:3–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The angel fills the censer “with the fire of the altar” and throws it on the earth – the same altar under which the souls cried “How long?” (6:9–10). Then the trumpets begin. Do you believe that your prayers are part of how God acts in the world? How would that change your intercession?

Revelation 8:5–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Compare the first, second and fourth trumpets with the plagues of Egypt (Exodus 9:23–25; 7:20–21; 10:21–23). What does the exodus tell us about the purpose of the trumpets – for Rome, and for every power that oppresses God's people? What is God aiming at: the destruction of creation, or the liberation of his people?

Revelation 8:7–12

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The locusts may harm “only the people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads”. The key, the authority and the five months – all are given. Their king Apollyon (“Destroyer”) is perhaps a dig at Apollo. What comfort did this give the churches in Asia? Where do you need to hear that evil is on a leash?

Revelation 9:1–11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“And the rest of humankind … did not even repent of the works of their hands”; like Pharaoh, they cling to idols “which can neither see nor hear nor walk” (Psalm 115:4–8). Which crisis in your life turned you to God – and which made you harder instead? What are the “works of your hands” that you trust more than God?

Revelation 9:20–21

DISCUSSION · 7/7

In Israel the trumpet was the watchman's alarm (Ezekiel 33:3–6) – a God who warns has not yet given up on the world. How do you respond to news of disasters – with fear, with speculation, or with prayer and repentance? Do you hear the call to repent as a threat or as an invitation?

Revelation 8:13

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Sit in silence for five minutes before you pray, every day this week. Then write down one injustice you have long been praying about, and bring it before God again – knowing that heaven is listening.
- Take ten minutes and ask yourself honestly: which “work of my hands” has taken my heart captive? Name it before God, and take one small step away from it – and towards him.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a full minute of silence together – no words, only remembering who sits on the throne. Then let each person pray one sentence for a situation they have long prayed about, or for persecuted believers. Close with Jesus' words to the churches (3:20), and thank him that he always lives to intercede for us (Hebrews 7:25).

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 7

Sweet and Bitter

Revelation 10:1 – 11:19

TO GET STARTED

Think of a food that you hated as a child but love now (or the other way round). What changed?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After the sixth trumpet we expect the seventh at once. But as between the sixth and the seventh seal, the story pauses. In chapter 7 God's people were sealed; in chapters 10 and 11 they are sent. John eats a little scroll, sweet in the mouth and bitter in the stomach, and must prophesy again; then he measures the temple and sees two witnesses who prophesy, are killed and stand up again. For the churches in Asia, living in Rome's cities, this was their calling: not to withdraw, but to bear witness.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 10:1–3

1 And I saw another mighty angel coming down from heaven, wrapped in a cloud,
and the rainbow was over his head, and his face was like the sun, and his feet were
like pillars of fire, 2 and he had in his hand a little scroll, opened. And he set his right
foot on the sea and his left foot on the earth, 3 and he cried out with a loud voice, as a
lion roars. And when he cried out, the seven thunders spoke with their own voices.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 10:4–6

4 And when the seven thunders had spoken, I was about to write; and I heard a voice
from heaven saying, "Seal up what the seven thunders have spoken, and do not
write it down!"

5 And the angel whom I saw standing on the sea and on the earth raised his right
hand to heaven 6 and swore by the one who lives for ever and ever, who created
heaven and what is in it, and the earth and what is in it, and the sea and what is in it,
that there will be no more delay,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 10:7–8

7 but that in the days of the voice of the seventh angel, when he is about to blow the
trumpet, the mystery of God is fulfilled, as he announced the good news to his
servants the prophets.

8 And the voice that I had heard from heaven spoke with me again and said, "Go,
take the scroll that lies open in the hand of the angel who is standing on the sea and
on the earth."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 10:9–11

9 And I went to the angel and told him to give me the little scroll. And he says to me,
"Take it and eat it up; it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be
sweet as honey." 10 And I took the little scroll from the hand of the angel and ate it
up, and it was sweet as honey in my mouth; and when I had eaten it, my stomach
was made bitter. 11 And they say to me, "You must prophesy again about many
peoples and nations and languages and kings."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:1–3

[1] And a reed like a staff was given to me, and I was told, "Get up and measure the
temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it. [2] But leave out the court
outside the temple, and do not measure it, for it has been given to the nations, and
they will trample the holy city for forty-two months. [3] And I will grant my two
witnesses that they prophesy for a thousand two hundred and sixty days, clothed in
sackcloth."

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:4–5

[4] These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord of
the earth. [5] And if anyone wants to harm them, fire comes out of their mouth and
devours their enemies; and if anyone should want to harm them, this is how he
must be killed.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:6–7

6 They have the authority to shut the sky, so that no rain falls during the days of
their prophecy; and they have authority over the waters, to turn them into blood
and to strike the earth with every plague, as often as they want.

7 And when they have finished their testimony, the beast that comes up from the
abyss will make war against them and conquer them and kill them.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:8–10

8 And their corpse lies in the street of the great city, which is spiritually called
Sodom and Egypt, where their Lord too was crucified. 9 And people from the
peoples and tribes and languages and nations look at their corpse for three and a
half days, and they do not allow their corpses to be laid in a tomb. 10 And those who
live on the earth are glad over them and rejoice, and they will send gifts to one
another, because these two prophets tormented those who live on the earth.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:11–12

11 And after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and
they stood on their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw them. 12 And they
heard a loud voice from heaven saying to them, "Come up here!" And they went up
to heaven in the cloud, and their enemies watched them.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:13–15

13 And in that hour there was a great earthquake, and a tenth of the city fell, and
seven thousand people were killed in the earthquake; and the rest were terrified
and gave glory to the God of heaven.

14 The second woe has passed; look, the third woe is coming soon.

15 And the seventh angel blew the trumpet; and there were loud voices in heaven,
saying:

The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's,
and he will reign for ever and ever.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:16–17

16 And the twenty-four elders who sit on their thrones before God fell on their faces
and worshipped God, 17 saying:

We give you thanks, Lord God, the Almighty,
who is and who was,
because you have taken your great power
and begun to reign.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:18–18

18 And the nations were angry,
and your wrath has come,
and the time for the dead to be judged,
and to give the reward to your servants the prophets
and to the saints and to those who fear your name,
the small and the great,
and to destroy those who destroy the earth.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 11:19–19

19 And God's temple in heaven was opened, and the ark of his covenant was seen in his temple; and there were lightning and sounds and thunder and an earthquake and great hail.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

χρόνος οὐκέτι ἔσται

chronos ouketi estai · "there will be no more delay"

Chronos usually means "time", and older translations read as if time itself would stop. But the oath echoes Daniel 12:7 and answers the "How long?" of 6:10: God will wait no longer (10:6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

κατάφαγε

kataphage · “eat it up”

Kataphagein does not mean to taste but to eat up completely (10:9). The word must go into the prophet before it can come out of him – as with Ezekiel, for whom the scroll was sweet as honey and then bitter (Ezekiel 2:8–3:3, 14).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μάρτυσίν

martysin · "witnesses"

We translate "witness", not "martyr" (11:3). But this chapter shows how the two words grew together in the early church: whoever bears faithful witness sometimes pays the price – like Antipas (2:13), and like Jesus himself, "the faithful witness" (1:5).

THE BIG IDEA

God's answer to a world that will not repent is his word in the mouth of his witnesses: the church eats the word, sweet and bitter, is measured and kept by God, bears witness in sackcloth, shares its Lord's death and resurrection – and the kingdom of the world has already become our Lord's and his Christ's.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Wrapped in a cloud, with a rainbow over his head, the angel sets one foot on the sea and the other on the earth and swears by the one “who created heaven and what is in it, and the earth and what is in it, and the sea and what is in it”. What do these images say about whose world this is?

Revelation 10:1–6

DISCUSSION · 2/7

John is told: “Seal up what the seven thunders have spoken, and do not write it down!” What does this say to people who use Revelation as a puzzle for dates and speculation? Which questions about the future make you restless – and can you leave them with God?

Revelation 10:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

The souls under the altar were told “to rest a little longer” (6:11). Now the angel swears “that there will be no more delay”. Read Habakkuk 2:3. Where have you long been waiting for God, and what does this oath say to you?

Revelation 10:5–7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Read Ezekiel 3:1–3 and 3:14 alongside Revelation 10:9–10: “Take it and eat it up; it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be sweet as honey.” Do you read the Bible more like someone who tastes or like someone who eats? Which part of God's word is sweet to you at the moment, and which part bitter?

Revelation 10:8–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

John measures “the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it”, but the outer court is trampled for forty-two months. In the New Testament the church is God's temple (1 Corinthians 3:16). Do you sometimes feel like the court that is trampled? What does it mean to you that God has measured the inner part?

Revelation 11:1–2

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands” – and the lampstands are the churches (1:20). Their signs are those of Elijah and Moses, and they stand not by might nor by power, but by God's Spirit (Zechariah 4:6). Where are you tempted to stay silent because your witness would make you unpopular?

Revelation 11:3–10

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The witnesses are killed and raised, and – unlike after the plagues (9:20–21) – the rest give glory to the God of heaven – through the testimony. The seventh trumpet sings: “The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's”. Where would it make a difference today if you truly believed that?

Revelation 11:11–19

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one short passage – Revelation 10:8–11, for example – and read it slowly and aloud every day for three days. “Chew” on it. Then share one sentence from it with someone who needs it.
- Think of one person around you who does not yet know Christ. Pray for him or her by name every day this week, and ask God for one opportunity to share something of your hope – gently, not fearfully.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 11:15 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank God that the kingdom of the world belongs to him and to his Christ; ask him for hunger for his word and courage when witness costs something; pray by name for the person each of you thought of. Close together with Zechariah 4:6: not by might nor by power, but by your Spirit.

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 8

Whose Are You?

Revelation 12:1 – 13:18

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been fooled by a fake – a counterfeit product, a forged signature, a scam message? How did you find out?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The seventh trumpet has sounded: the kingdom of the world has become our Lord's. Now John draws the curtain back further and shows how it came about. Chapter 12 tells the Christmas story from behind the curtain: a woman, a child, a dragon – and the accuser thrown down. In chapter 13 the dragon calls up two beasts, from the sea and from the earth. For the churches in Asia the beast had a face: Rome, the imperial cult and the guilds, where you could not buy or sell without offering incense to the emperor.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:1–3

[1] And a great sign appeared in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars. [2] And she was pregnant, and she cries out in labour and in torment to give birth.

[3] And another sign appeared in heaven, and look, a great fiery red dragon, with seven heads and ten horns, and on its heads seven diadems.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:4–5

4 And its tail sweeps away a third of the stars of heaven, and it threw them to the
earth. And the dragon stood before the woman who was about to give birth, so that
when she gave birth it might devour her child. 5 And she gave birth to a son, a male
child, who is to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod. And her child was
snatched up to God and to his throne.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:6–8

6 And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she has a place prepared by God, so
that there she might be fed for a thousand two hundred and sixty days.

7 And war broke out in heaven: Michael and his angels made war against the dragon.
And the dragon made war, and its angels, 8 but it was not strong enough, and no
place was found for them in heaven any longer.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:9–10

9 And the great dragon was thrown down, the ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, who deceives the whole world – he was thrown down to the earth, and his angels were thrown down with him.

10 And I heard a loud voice in heaven saying:

Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God
and the authority of his Christ,
for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down,
who accuses them before our God day and night.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:11–11

11 And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb
and by the word of their testimony,
and they did not love their life even to death.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:12–12

12 Therefore rejoice, you heavens,
and you whose tent is in them!
Woe to the earth and the sea,
for the devil has come down to you
with great fury,
because he knows that he has only a little time.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:13–15

13 And when the dragon saw that it had been thrown down to the earth, it pursued
the woman who had given birth to the male child. 14 And the two wings of the great
eagle were given to the woman, so that she might fly into the wilderness to her
place, where she is fed for a time and times and half a time, away from the face of
the serpent. 15 And the serpent spewed water like a river out of its mouth after the
woman, so that the river would sweep her away.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 12:16–18

16 And the earth helped the woman, and the earth opened its mouth and swallowed
the river that the dragon had spewed out of its mouth. 17 And the dragon was angry
with the woman and went off to make war against the rest of her offspring, those
who keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus. 18 And it
took its stand on the sand of the sea.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:1–3

[1] And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea, with ten horns and seven heads, and on its horns ten diadems, and on its heads names of blasphemy. [2] And the beast that I saw was like a leopard, and its feet were like a bear's, and its mouth like a lion's mouth. And the dragon gave it its power and its throne and great authority. [3] And one of its heads seemed slaughtered to death, and its death wound was healed. And the whole earth followed the beast in amazement,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:4–6

4 and they worshipped the dragon, because it had given the authority to the beast,
and they worshipped the beast, saying, "Who is like the beast, and who can make
war against it?"

5 And it was given a mouth speaking great things and blasphemies, and it was given
authority to act for forty-two months. 6 And it opened its mouth in blasphemies
against God, to blaspheme his name and his tent – those whose tent is in heaven.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:7–9

7 And it was allowed to make war against the saints and to conquer them, and it was given authority over every tribe and people and language and nation. 8 And all who live on the earth will worship it – everyone whose name has not been written in the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb from the foundation of the world.

9 If anyone has an ear, he should hear.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:10–12

10 If anyone is for captivity, into captivity he goes; if anyone is to be killed with the
sword, with the sword he will be killed. Here is the endurance and the faith of the
saints.

11 And I saw another beast coming up out of the earth, and it had two horns like a
lamb, and it spoke like a dragon. 12 And it exercises all the authority of the first beast
in its presence, and it makes the earth and those who live on it worship the first
beast, whose death wound was healed.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:13–14

13 And it performs great signs, so that it even makes fire come down from heaven to
the earth before people. 14 And it deceives those who live on the earth by the signs
that it was allowed to perform in the presence of the beast, telling those who live on
the earth to make an image for the beast that has the wound of the sword and came
to life.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:15–17

15 And it was allowed to give breath to the image of the beast, so that the image of the
beast would even speak and would cause all who do not worship the image of the
beast to be killed. 16 And it makes everyone, the small and the great, the rich and the
poor, the free and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their
forehead, 17 so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark: the name of the
beast or the number of its name.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 13:18–18

18 Here is wisdom: whoever has understanding should calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a human being. And its number is six hundred and sixty-six.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὁ κατήγωρ

ho katēgōr · "the accuser"

A word from the courtroom (12:10) – exactly what the Hebrew *hassatan* means in Job 1–2 and Zechariah 3: the adversary, the accuser in God's heavenly council. He accuses them "before our God day and night" – but now he has been thrown down.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὡς ἐσφαγμένην

hōs esphagmenēn · “seemed slaughtered”

The same expression as for the Lamb in 5:6 (*hōs esphagmenon*). John wants us to notice the likeness – and the difference (13:3). The Lamb's wounds are for others; the beast's healing is for itself. Evil creates nothing new. It imitates.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

χάραγμα

charagma · “mark”

A stamp or impression – also the emperor's stamp on coins and documents (13:16–17). Every coin in the hand of a trader in Thyatira bore the emperor's image and titles. The mark is “the name of the beast or the number of its name”: it says whom you belong to.

THE BIG IDEA

Behind the curtain the dragon has already been thrown down by the blood of the Lamb; in his fury he works through beasts that imitate the Lamb and demand worship – but God's people, sealed before the beast ever appeared, conquer by the blood of the Lamb, the word of their testimony and endurance, for the question is not “when?” but “whose are you?”.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Read Genesis 3:15 and 37:9: what do they tell us about the woman, the child and the dragon? The child “is to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod” (Psalm 2:9) and is “snatched up to God and to his throne” – the whole life of Jesus in one sentence. What is different when we see Bethlehem from behind the curtain?

Revelation 12:1–6

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Read Zechariah 3:1–5 and Job 1:9–11: the accuser could still stand before God. Now “the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down”. Which accusation do you hear most often in your own thoughts? How does the Spirit's conviction, which leads to the cross, differ from the accuser's voice, which ends in despair?

Revelation 12:7–10

DISCUSSION · 3/7

They conquered “by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony”, and “they did not love their life even to death”. Do you try to silence the accuser with your own good works, or do you take refuge in the blood of the Lamb? What would it mean for you to speak the word of your testimony?

Revelation 12:11–12

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The woman is given “the two wings of the great eagle” and is fed in the wilderness (Exodus 19:4). The church is on its exodus through this age – not out of creation, but out of the dragon's power. Where are you in the wilderness at the moment, and where can you see that God is feeding you there?

Revelation 12:13–18

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Read Daniel 7:2–8 and 17: John's beast is leopard, bear and lion in one body. The crowd cries: “Who is like the beast, and who can make war against it?” – a counterfeit of Israel's song (Exodus 15:11). What did the beast look like for the churches in Asia? Which powers lay claim to people's whole heart today?

Revelation 13:1–8

DISCUSSION · 6/7

One of its heads “seemed slaughtered to death”, and the second beast “had two horns like a lamb, and it spoke like a dragon”. Why is the convincing copy more dangerous for the church than the open enemy? Where are you drawn by something that looks like a lamb but speaks like a dragon?

Revelation 13:3–15

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The mark is given “on their right hand or on their forehead”, and without it no one can buy or sell. Compare God's seal (7:3) and the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:8): what you think and what you do. No one is unmarked. If someone had watched your week: whom do your hand and your forehead belong to?

Revelation 13:16–18

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down one accusation you hear again and again in your head. Next to it write: “for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down” (12:10). Read it aloud when the voice comes back.
- Choose one “hand” choice (something you do) and one “forehead” pattern (something you think) where the beast is pulling at you. Pray about them every day this week with the words: I belong to the Lamb.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 12:10–11 aloud together. Then let each person thank God in one sentence that they belong to the Lamb, and – if they want to – name one place where they feel the pressure to “buy or sell” by playing along. Close with the confession of the devotional: Who is a God like you? (Micah 7:18), and thank him that our names are written in “the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb” (13:8).

BEHIND THE CURTAIN · SESSION 9

The Song on the Shore

Revelation 14:1 – 16:21

TO GET STARTED

Is there a song that carries you through hard times – one you sing or hum when things are difficult? What does it do for you?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In chapter 13 the dragon and his two beasts seemed to rule the world, and no one could buy or sell without the beast's mark. Chapters 14–16 draw back the curtain again: the Lamb stands on Mount Zion with the whole people of God, angels proclaim an eternal gospel and the harvest of the earth is gathered in. Then come the seven last plagues: before a single bowl is poured out, the conquerors sing on the shore of the sea of glass, and then the bowls fall like the plagues of Egypt on the kingdom of the beast – until the voice from the throne cries, “It is done!”

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:1–2

[1] And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion, and with him a
hundred and forty-four thousand who had his name and his Father's name written
on their foreheads. [2] And I heard a sound from heaven like the sound of many
waters and like the sound of loud thunder; and the sound that I heard was like lyre
players playing on their lyres.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:3–4

3 And they sing something like a new song before the throne and before the four
living creatures and the elders; and no one could learn the song except the hundred
and forty-four thousand, who have been purchased from the earth. 4 These are the
ones who have not defiled themselves with women, for they are virgins. These are
the ones who follow the Lamb wherever he goes. These were purchased from
among people as firstfruits for God and for the Lamb,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:5–7

5 and no lie was found in their mouth; they are without blemish.

6 And I saw another angel flying in midheaven, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to
those who are settled on the earth and to every nation and tribe and language and
people. 7 He said with a loud voice, "Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his
judgement has come; and worship the one who made heaven and earth and sea and
the springs of water!"

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:8–9

8 And another, a second angel, followed, saying, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great,
who has made all the nations drink of the wine of the fury of her harlotry!"

9 And another, a third angel, followed them, saying with a loud voice, "If anyone
worships the beast and its image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his
hand,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:10–12

10 he too will drink of the wine of the fury of God, poured undiluted into the cup of
his wrath, and he will be tormented with fire and sulphur before holy angels and
before the Lamb. 11 And the smoke of their torment goes up for ever and ever, and
they have no rest day or night, those who worship the beast and its image, and
whoever receives the mark of its name." 12 Here is the endurance of the saints, those
who keep the commandments of God and faith in Jesus.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:13–14

13 And I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Write: Blessed are the dead who die in
the Lord from now on." "Yes," says the Spirit, "so that they may rest from their toil,
for their works go with them."

14 And I looked, and there was a white cloud, and seated on the cloud was one like a
son of man, with a golden crown on his head and a sharp sickle in his hand.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:15–17

15 And another angel came out of the temple, crying out with a loud voice to the one
seated on the cloud, "Send out your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come,
for the harvest of the earth is dry and ripe." 16 And the one seated on the cloud swung
his sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped.

17 And another angel came out of the temple in heaven, and he too had a sharp
sickle.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:18–19

18 And another angel came from the altar, the one who has authority over the fire,
and he called with a loud voice to the one who had the sharp sickle, saying, "Send
out your sharp sickle and gather the clusters from the vine of the earth, for its
grapes are ripe." 19 And the angel swung his sickle over the earth and gathered the
vintage of the vine of the earth and threw it into the great winepress of the fury of
God.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 14:20 – 15:1

20 And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out of the
winepress up to the horses' bridles, for a distance of a thousand six hundred stadia.

1 And I saw another sign in heaven, great and wonderful: seven angels with seven
plagues, the last ones, for with them the fury of God is completed.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 15:2–3

2 And I saw something like a sea of glass mixed with fire, and those who conquer the
beast and its image and the number of its name, standing beside the sea of glass,
holding lyres of God. 3 And they sing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the
song of the Lamb, saying:

Great and wonderful are your works,
Lord God, the Almighty;
just and true are your ways,
King of the ages.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 15:4–4

4 Who will not fear you, Lord,
and glorify your name?
For you alone are holy.
For all the nations will come
and worship before you,
for your righteous acts have been revealed.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 15:5–7

5 And after this I looked, and the temple of the tent of witness in heaven was opened,
6 and the seven angels who had the seven plagues came out of the temple, dressed in
clean, shining linen, with golden sashes around their chests. 7 And one of the four
living creatures gave the seven angels seven golden bowls full of the fury of God,
who lives for ever and ever.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 15:8 – 16:2

8 And the temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and from his power,
and no one could enter the temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels were
completed.

1 And I heard a loud voice from the temple saying to the seven angels, "Go and pour
out the seven bowls of the fury of God on the earth!"

2 And the first went and poured out his bowl on the earth; and a foul and evil sore
came on the people who had the mark of the beast and who worshipped its image.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:3–5

3 And the second poured out his bowl into the sea; and it became blood like that of a
dead man, and every living soul died, everything that was in the sea.

4 And the third poured out his bowl into the rivers and the springs of water; and
they became blood. 5 And I heard the angel of the waters say:

Just are you, who is and who was, the Holy One,
because you have judged these things;

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:6–7

6 for they poured out the blood of saints and prophets,
and you have given them blood to drink.
They deserve it.
7 And I heard the altar say:

Yes, Lord God, the Almighty,
true and just are your judgements.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:8–10

8 And the fourth poured out his bowl on the sun; and it was allowed to scorch people
with fire. 9 And the people were scorched with fierce heat, and they blasphemed the
name of God, who has authority over these plagues, and they did not repent and
give him glory.

10 And the fifth poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast; and its kingdom was
plunged into darkness, and people gnawed their tongues in pain,

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:11–13

11 and they blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores, and
they did not repent of their works.

12 And the sixth poured out his bowl on the great river, the Euphrates; and its water
was dried up, so that the way would be prepared for the kings from the rising of the
sun. 13 And I saw coming out of the mouth of the dragon and out of the mouth of the
beast and out of the mouth of the false prophet three unclean spirits like frogs.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:14–16

14 For they are spirits of demons that perform signs, and they go out to the kings of
the whole world, to gather them for the war of the great day of God, the Almighty.
15 – "Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his
clothes, so that he does not walk around naked and people see his shame." – 16 And
they gathered them at the place that is called in Hebrew Armageddon.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:17–19

17 And the seventh poured out his bowl into the air; and a loud voice came out of the
temple, from the throne, saying, "It is done!" 18 And there were lightning and sounds
and thunder, and there was a great earthquake, such as there had never been since
people were on the earth, so great an earthquake, so mighty. 19 And the great city
split into three parts, and the cities of the nations fell. And God remembered
Babylon the Great, to give her the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath.

READ TOGETHER · REVELATION 16:20–21

20 And every island fled, and mountains were not found. 21 And great hail, each stone as heavy as a talent, comes down from heaven on the people; and the people blasphemed God because of the plague of the hail, for its plague is exceedingly great.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

γεγραμμένον ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων αὐτῶν

gegrammenon epi tōn metōpōn autōn · “written on their foreheads”

The verb form describes something that has been written and stays written. The mark of the beast has to be enforced (13:16); the name of the Lamb and of his Father is a lasting gift (14:1; cf. 7:3; 22:4). No one is unmarked – everyone belongs to someone.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

τὴν ᾠδὴν Μωϋσέως … καὶ τὴν ᾠδὴν τοῦ ἀρνίου

tēn ōdēn Mōyseōs … kai tēn ōdēn tou arniou · "the song of Moses … and the song of the Lamb"

Probably not two songs but one: the song of the exodus (Exodus 15), now sung about a greater exodus. The blood of the Passover lamb brought Israel out of Egypt; the blood of the Lamb has purchased people for God from every nation (5:9).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

Γέγονεν

Gegonen · “It is done!”

The perfect tense: something has happened and stands. The kings are still gathering for war, yet the outcome is already decided. The same word sounds again at the new creation (21:6).

THE BIG IDEA

After the dragon and the beasts, the curtain opens on the Lamb standing on Zion with his people, who bear his name and sing the song of Moses and of the Lamb before a single bowl is poured out – God's judgement on evil is real and just, but those who belong to the Lamb are kept, and the end of evil has already been decided.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

After the beast's mark: “And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion”. The dragon stood on the sand of the sea (12:18); the Lamb stands on the rock of Zion. What would this have meant to a believer in Pergamum who felt almost alone in not bowing down? Where do you need this look behind the curtain today?

Revelation 14:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

The 144,000 have “his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads” and follow the Lamb wherever he goes. Which label (job, income, looks, failures) weighs on you most, and what changes when his name is written over it? Where are you reluctant to follow the Lamb at the moment?

Revelation 14:1–5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Before the fall of Babylon and the solemn warning, an angel flies with “an eternal gospel” for every nation: “Fear God and give him glory”. Why do you think the gospel comes first? And what does verse 13 say to someone who has lost a loved one in the Lord?

Revelation 14:6–13

DISCUSSION · 4/7

The conquerors stand beside the sea of glass and sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb”. Read Exodus 15:1–2, 11 and Jeremiah 10:6–7 aloud. What links do you see between Israel on the shore of the Red Sea and God's people here? What is the greater exodus the Lamb has brought about?

Revelation 15:2–4

DISCUSSION · 5/7

The song comes before the bowls, and there is not a word in it about the singers' own suffering or courage – every line is about God. Where are you standing at the moment: still in the sea, or already on the shore? What would it mean to sing “just and true are your ways” there already?

Revelation 15:3–4

DISCUSSION · 6/7

The bowls bring back the plagues of Egypt (Exodus 7–10). Twice we read that “they did not repent”, and three times that they blasphemed God. What does Pharaoh's story teach about why judgement alone does not change a heart? When something hurts, do you become softer or harder towards God?

Revelation 16:1–11

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The altar says: “Yes, Lord God, the Almighty, true and just are your judgements.” And Christ says: “Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes”. How do these voices comfort those who suffer injustice? What does “staying awake” mean for you – without calculating dates?

Revelation 16:5–17

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Tonight write on a card: I belong to the Lamb. Put it by the mirror, and each morning read 15:3–4 aloud and thank God for one concrete work he has done in your life.
- Take two minutes one evening to ask where you have fallen asleep this week – in prayer, honesty or love. Then pray for one person or place that suffers injustice, using the words of 16:7.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 15:3–4 aloud together, or sing a song of praise the group knows. Then pray in twos or threes: thank the Lamb that his name is written over your life, name one situation in which you feel you are still in the sea, and pray for one place in the world that suffers injustice. Close together with 16:7: “Yes, Lord God, the Almighty, true and just are your judgements.”